GOTHAM CENTRAL: SOFT TARGETS

Details **Originally published** Gotham Central #12-#15 (2003)
Publisher DC **Writers** Ed Brubaker, Greg Rucka **Artist** Michael Lark
Collected in Gotham Central: Jokers And Madmen **Available digitally** Comixology, Kindle Fire

While Batman's impossible intellect and physical prowess hold the reader at arms length, *Gotham Central* does the opposite. It turns you into a Gotham citizen and makes you appreciate what it would be like to live in Batman's town, constantly under threat of attack by some crazed supervillain.

We're taken on a ride-along with Gotham Central PD's finest – a remarkably huge ensemble – as they try to police a city that's in the thrall of an illegal vigilante. We go home with the detectives, get to know them, start to understand their in-jokes and complex rivalries. They become far more than just the cops who show up at the end of a Batman story to arrest the bad guy he's already beaten unconscious. They are the story.

Soft Targets takes that set-up, and throws the Joker into the middle of it. Through Batman's eyes the Joker is a nutjob who will inevitably be defeated. But through the eyes of the GCPD, he is the call every police officer dreads. Joker's usually throw-away collateral damage becomes the heart of this story, the jewel in the crown of Brubaker, Rucka and Lark's near-perfect series. He's never been scarier.





